THE PAPER LANTERN

Written by

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Placeholder Pictures
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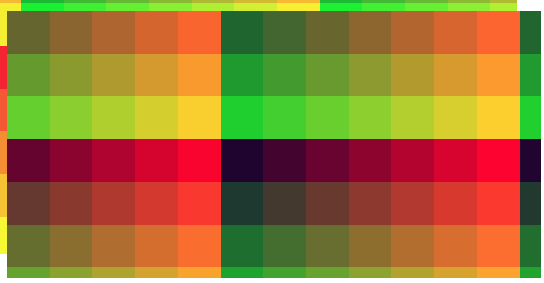
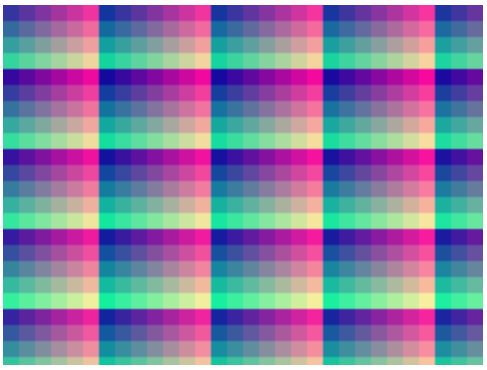


INT. ARCHIVE ROOM - DAY

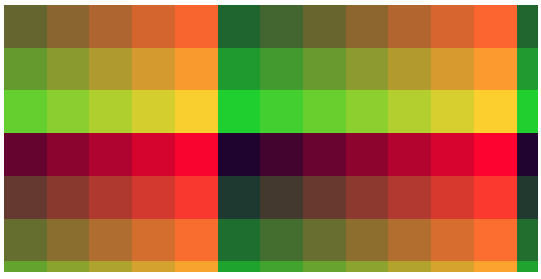


WREN, 30s, holds a storyboard panel up to the window and squints at it.

WREN
Somebody drew this in 1974 and nobody has looked at it since.

HOLT sets down a box of film cans.

HOLT
That is the job.



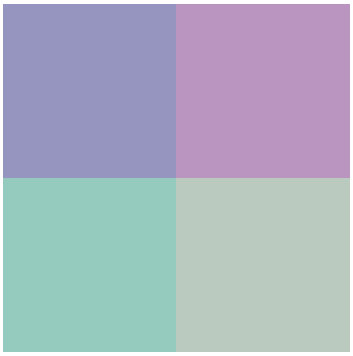
INT. ARCHIVE ROOM - PROJECTION BOOTH - LATER

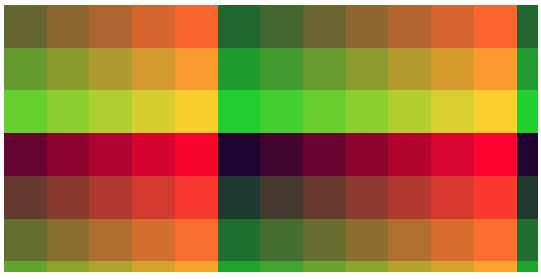
A splice reel turns. The room smells of vinegar and dust.

HOLT
Two frames are missing from the head of the roll.

WREN
Then we cut around them.

She threads the leader by feel, the way she was taught.





EXT. LOADING DOCK - NIGHT

Rain on corrugated steel. WREN wheels a cart of film cans out under a sodium lamp and counts them twice.

HOLT holds an umbrella over the cart and not over himself.

WREN
Forty-one. There were forty-three when we started.

HOLT
Two of them went out for repair in March and nobody wrote it down.

WREN
Nobody ever writes it down.

She pulls a tarp over the cart and ties it at the corners.

HOLT
The truck comes at six. Everything on that manifest has to be on the dock by then, in order, and dry.

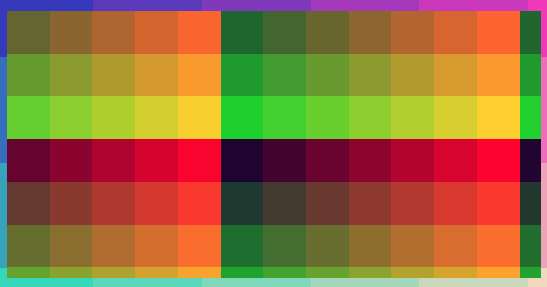
WREN
Then we work through it.

The lamp buzzes and cuts out. Neither of them stops moving.

In the dark the cart is a long shape and the rain is louder than it was.

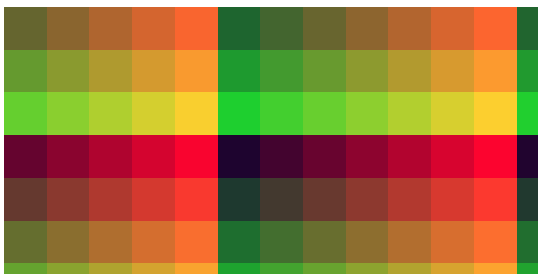
WREN
Bring the second cart. And the good tarp, not the one with the hole in it.

Holt goes. Wren stands in the rain with a clipboard and does not hurry.



INT. ARCHIVE ROOM - DAWN

The cart is gone. A single storyboard panel is still pinned to the window.

WREN
Leave that one.

FADE OUT.